

Bangladesh

 Formed in 1971 when it became independent of Pakistan, Bangladesh has a troubled political history. Democracy was restored in 1991, after a period of military rule. Bangladesh has one of the world's highest population densities and half of its people live in poverty. The country's vast water resources provide good farming conditions, but floods and cyclones wreak seasonal havoc.



Stilt houses

Many people live in houses that are built on stilts to protect them from the frequent floods. The country is overcrowded, and about 75 per cent of the people live in rural communities. Most grow just enough rice to live on, and fish in the Ganges.



Jute rope

Jute

Bangladesh is second only to India in the production of jute, a tough fibre used for sacking, rope, and carpeting. The country provides about 80 per cent of the world's jute fibre. Jute products make up 13 per cent of Bangladesh's exports.

Silkworms spin a silky thread up to 1 km (0.6 miles) long.



Dhaka

The capital, Dhaka, lies on the Buriganga River, which links ports around the country. This has made it a centre of trade and commerce. The city contains more than eight million people, many of whom live in overcrowded slums.

Textiles

Many Bangladeshis work in the textile industry, with cotton and silk the country's leading fabrics. Ready-made garments are the main product, totalling 60 per cent of exports. Women are the backbone of the textile industry.

Nepal

 The Himalayas and their forested foothills cover most of this land-locked country. Nepal was an absolute monarchy until 1991, but now has a multi-party constitution. It is one of the world's poorest countries; the people are mostly farmers whose crops depend on the monsoon rains.

People

There is a wide variety of peoples in Nepal, and most are of Indian or Tibetan descent. The Sherpas of the north are skilled, tough mountaineers. About 90 per cent of Nepalese people are Hindus, who combine their religion with Buddhism.

Hindu holy man



Farming

Nepal is dependent on farming, which, with forestry, employs 90 per cent of the work-force. Rice, maize, and sugar are grown on terraces cut into the mountainsides.

Katmandu

Lying in a valley 1,370 m (4,500 ft) above sea-level, Nepal's capital, Katmandu, is a city full of ornate temples and shrines. About 400,000 people live in the city, including the Newars of the valley who are famed for their wood carving.



Buddhist temple overlooking Katmandu.

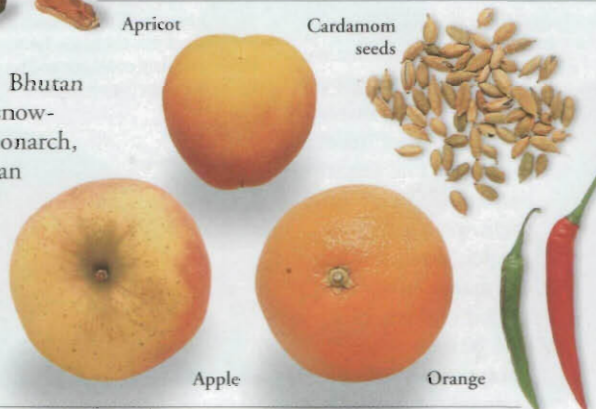


Trekking

Mountain climbing and trekking in the Himalayas attract 450,000 visitors to Nepal each year. Tourism attracts much-needed income, but threatens the ecology.

Bhutan

 A small, isolated country, Bhutan is covered in forests and snow-capped mountains. Ruled by a monarch, known as the Dragon King, it is an isolated state, though there are plans for modernization. Three-quarters of the people are of Tibetan descent; the rest are Nepalese or Hindus. Farming, fishing, forestry, and small-scale industry provide jobs.



Crops

Less than ten per cent of Bhutan's land can be cultivated, but 90 per cent of the people make a living from farming. Rice, maize, and potatoes are the staple foods, and cash crops, such as apricots, apples, chillies, cardamom, and oranges, for export to other Asian countries, are being developed in the fertile central valleys.

Chilli peppers

BHUTAN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Thimphu
AREA	47,000 sq km (18,147 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,100,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Dzongkha
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Buddhist, Hindu
CURRENCY	Ngultrum

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